

SUPPLEMENTARY SHEET 1

Role Descriptions for Mystery Jeans Inc.



Here are five role descriptions. Photocopy and cut out the descriptions for your participants. Make sure that each role player does not know the description of the other roles beforehand. Ask each player to study his/her role for five minutes and then do a one-minute presentation representing her/his role. Each person should start his/her presentation by introducing themselves (for example, "I am C, a worker or I am Ms. K, a concerned citizen").

REPRESENTATIVE FROM MYSTERY JEANS INC.

You are a representative from the North American head office of Mystery Jeans Inc. Your company is very interested in building a plant in Maquila because it knows its profits are substantially higher in the developing world than in industrialised countries. (For example, Mexican garment workers earn one fifth to one tenth the hourly rate paid in North American garment factories, resulting in substantial savings.)

You have the advantage of being able to corner local markets and to export to First World countries taking advantage of lower wages, tax rebates, relaxed environmental laws, government restrictions on unions and political stability.

You are concerned that profits not appear to be the only motivation for your interest in this country, even though you believe there is nothing wrong with making a profit. You feel that Maquila should welcome your company for the following reasons:

- Your plant will provide 2,000 new jobs in a country where unemployment is very high.
- Your plant will bring new and advanced technology into the country.
- Because you are a multinational corporation, you will help the country to obtain export markets to which it does not presently have access. This will provide foreign exchange to the country for payment of foreign imports and debts.

A LOCAL GARMENT MAKER

You are a local garment maker in Maquila.

You run a small garment manufacturing company that employs many talented tailors and seamstresses to produce clothing for the local market.

You are opposed to Mystery Jean Inc. building a plant in your community for the following reasons:

You would like to expand your garment business in the future. To do that, you need loans, and these are difficult to obtain because capital is scarce. If Mystery Jeans builds a plant, banks will prefer to give loans to them because they are bigger and more secure. That means no loans for your company and no expansion. You do not have access to foreign bank loans and "aid funds" as larger companies do.

You are afraid that Mystery Jeans Inc. will drive you, and other small companies like yours, out of business. (Global corporations are able to use local finance capital and their technological advantage to absorb local industry.) A very large company can drive a smaller one out of business through superior advertising, control or take over of export markets, or by lowering its prices until the small business can no longer afford to compete.



WORKER

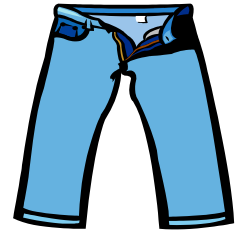
You are a Maquila worker.

- Unemployment in Maquila is very high and, although you are presently employed, unemployment is a constant fear.
- You find the Mystery Jeans Inc. promise of 2,000 new jobs appealing, but you are sceptical about how much this will actually benefit Maquila people.
- You know that Mystery Jeans Inc. uses a much more automated process (sewing machines) than local garment companies and thus employs fewer people to make the same number of garments. (Statistics have shown that the expansion of global corporations has contributed to the expansion of world unemployment. The sales of the world's top 200 corporations are equivalent of 27.5 percent of the world economic activity, yet they only employ 0.78 percent of the world's workforce.) Modernisation may increase "efficiency", but people lose jobs.
- Wages within the global corporations are frequently low - much lower than wages for comparable work in First World countries.
- Even though wages paid by global corporations are sometimes above average wages received by workers in the developing world, they are frequently less than subsistence.
- The company will bring in new technology, but this will mean work is more automated, more routine and less highly skilled. This kind of technology is very expensive. It makes more sense, given the high unemployment rate, to use more labour and simpler technology.

FIRST CITIZEN

You are a fairly wealthy landowner in Maquila.

- You stand to benefit greatly from the presence of Mystery Jeans Inc. in this country.
- The new plant will attract other industry and service, and land prices will rise.
- You know that multinational corporations can raise the GNP of a country. (For example, since the establishment of the North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA) in 1994, business began flowing in from the US. Trade with the United States and Canada has nearly doubled since the North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA) was implemented in 1994.)
- Mexico profits from a thriving garment industry, where the Mexican government allows U.S. companies to ship parts to border assembly plants without paying duties along the border. Many products are assembled inexpensively by Mexican labourers at U.S.-owned plants in Mexico, and then exported back to the United States and elsewhere.
- Maquila needs foreign trade in order to develop its economy, and international trade is largely controlled by multinational corporations like Mystery Jeans Inc.



SECOND CITIZEN

You are a community worker in Maquila. You work with and are concerned about the poor of this country.

You are opposed to Mystery Jeans Inc. building a plant here because you believe that multinational investment negatively affects the development of developing countries.

You think of the example of Mexico, where multinational investments have skyrocketed since the North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA) in 1994. Since then, the GDP has increased from \$330 Billion in 1996 to \$614 Billion in 2001, but 40% of the population remain below the poverty line. Because multinationals control international trade, they control prices and profits. International companies trade among themselves and make profits in the process - profits that go to shareholders in the First World and not to developing countries. Profits are high for multinationals in the developing world.